

The Skin Can Fail. There Is No Code.

Krasner D, Maguire J, Rosen R et al. (2026). PAWSIC Skin Failure Codes Position Paper (PSFCPP). Version 1.1, September 30, 2026.



Skin Failure Is Real

Clinically distinct from pressure injury, seen across critical, palliative, and end-of-life care.



But No ICD-10-CM Code Exists

Nothing to document it, measure it, or research it consistently in the medical record.



What is skin failure? An increasingly recognized clinical phenomenon in which the skin, the body's largest organ, sustains injury from systemic physiologic compromise such as hypoperfusion, multi-organ dysfunction, critical illness, advanced frailty, or the dying process, not just pressure and mechanical forces alone.

9A · PAWSIC POSITION STATEMENT

PAWSIC recognizes skin failure as a distinct clinical phenomenon and supports the development of an ICD-10-CM skin failure code framework that reflects contemporary clinical practice, while allowing for continued scientific refinement as evidence evolves.

9B · PAWSIC RECOMMENDATIONS



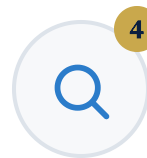
Recognize skin failure in ICD-10-CM



Align clinical & regulatory frameworks



Support precision & accountability



Promote skin failure research



Refine as evidence evolves



WHY NOW

October 2023 CMS guidance states that Skin Changes at Life's End (SCALE), Kennedy Terminal Ulcers (KTUs), and skin failure are not primarily caused by pressure and should not be documented as pressure injuries on the Minimum Data Set (MDS), yet no diagnostic code exists to make that distinction.



READ & ENDORSE

Read the paper, then add your name
pawsic.org/skin-failure-position-paper/read

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